

s for scaled architectures

- Ask customer to provide an architecture diagram and upload to collaboration project
- Ensure customer has Backup/Restore and Disaster Recovery plans in place

Conducting the call

If the CSM has sufficiently prepared, the call itself should be a comfortable and valuable experience for everyone involved. The CSM should be prepared to conduct the meeting according to the agenda and cover all of the listed discussion points. This is our chance to help the customer make forward progress on their objectives by sharing our expertise and answering their questions!

The CSM should drive the call proactively so the customer sees a value in it and comes away feeling they have gotten something out of it. Try to ask questions to get into discussions and let the customer talk most of the time. When putting together the call agenda, ensure that you are covering topics that help you with your customer strategy, but also ask yourself "if I were the customer, would I find this relevant?"

In addition to the GitLab external communication guidelines, here are a few tips for having a strong cadence call:

- Be engaged. It's acceptable at GitLab to multitask or divert your attention during meetings, but during a cadence call this isn't a good idea. The CSM is leading this call, and it's important to follow what is being discussed and keep the conversation moving to make the most of the allotted time. The CSM should be guiding the discussion, and taking notes (or have already asked another member of the account team to take notes).
- Be flexible. Having an agenda is crucial to a well-run cadence call, but it's equally important to be ready to go off-script. If the customer has something urgent that they need to discuss, or the conversation goes on a tangent that may yield good information, don't try to force it back to the prepared agenda. Address the customer concerns, embrace new information with relevant questions, and anything on the agenda that isn't critical can be delayed until the next cadence call. This relates to being "audible-ready" in customer conversations.
- Be responsive. No matter how much the CSM and account team prepare for the call, the customer can still throw a curveball. If they ask for information nobody on the call knows, be honest and acknowledge that, but make a plan to get that information and follow up. If you think you can answer the question, make an effort but still assure the customer you will verify what the best answer is. Do your best in the moment, and follow up on everything else in a timely manner.

Before you end the call, take a few minutes to summarize the highlights of what was discussed, and review the action items and who is responsible for each of them. It's also worth reminding everyone of when the next cadence call is.

After the call

If there are no action items or follow-ups that come from a cadence call, the call was not effective. At minimum, the CSM should send a follow-up email or create a follow-up issue for the participants covering the summary information that was discussed at the end of the call, answer any questions that were posed during the call, and make sure everyone knows what the action items from the call were.

Review and update account details

After a call, there are a few items to review and update to ensure the content from the call isn't lost and you maintain a positive relationship with the customer.

- Log the Timeline entry
- Update health score
- Update Success Plan as needed
- Update CTAs as needed
- Follow up on any action items (questions, feature requests, escalations, etc.)
- Send a follow up to the customer

It's a good idea to start creating the agenda for the next cadence call at this point, while the call that just ended is fresh in mind.

Follow up

When crafting your follow up messages to customers, follow the below recommended guidelines to ensure a positive experience.

1. Strive to send your follow up email or open the follow up issue as soon as possible, or within one business day of your call. If it will take longer than that, set expectations with your customers upfront and keep them posted on progress (even if there isn't any).
1. Address every action item, and if you don't have an update yet, let them know that you're working on it and an estimated turnaround time.
1. Keep your email/issue as succinct as possible, as customers probably don't want to read lengthy emails.
1. Share links whenever possible, however:
 1. Try to include the full link and not hyperlink on words, so that the customer knows what they're about to click on.
 1. Include a short summary of what the link contains so they understand why it's valuable to them before they click on it.
1. Often, we ask questions posed in customer calls to other GitLab team members. Don't copy & paste exactly your conversation; edit it to make sure it flows and makes sense to the customer and only contains the information they need.
1. Proofread! Before clicking send, always re-read your emails (aloud if that helps) to ensure it makes sense and doesn't have any errors. Remember customers don't always have as much context as we do, so read it from their perspective.
1. Make sure you BCC Salesforce on your emails. For important emails, you can also BCC Gainsight, but this is not recommended for all emails as it can make the Timeline noisy.

Cadence Call Notes

All customer call notes should be saved in Google Drive, following this format: /Sales/Customers & Prospects/A/Acme/Acme - Meeting Notes. See an example meeting notes [here](#). For customers who have lengthy notes doc, such as those who have been customers for several years, it is recommended to break out their notes into separate docs for each FY inside of their customer folder. When doing so, add the FY to the doc titles, for example /Sales/Customers & Prospects/A/Acme/Acme - Meeting Notes - FYXX and link all previous years' docs at the top of the current notes doc for easy access.

The rationale for saving call notes in this manner is as follows:

- The naming convention ""Customer - Meeting Notes" allows for fast searching using Google Cloud Search for Work
- Call notes frequently contain sensitive information and are for the internal sales team and management to review and should be kept in a place everyone who might need access can find them.
- A folder structure allows non-Customer Success executives and support staff to easily locate the notes in the case of an escalation.
- Call notes are tightly linked to the health score and should be available for reference in the same location as the health scorecard in Gainsight.
- Access to Gainsight is limited to CSMs, so other members of the Sales and Customer Success organizations will look for notes in Google Drive.
- If a team member who created the Google Doc leaves GitLab, the notes will remain accessible to everyone, as they live in the shared Google Drive folder.
- By breaking notes out into separate docs for each FY, we avoid having slowness when loading and typing into the docs and we are able to better parse the data.

Customer call notes should also always be linked in the C360 for the account, under the "Summary" tab, in the "Account Attributes (Editable)" section, in the "Google Doc Notes" field.

When CSMs are logging calls in Gainsight Timeline, they need to copy & paste the link to the Google Doc. They should either write a simple summary of the meeting along with the link, or have the link be a direct deep link to the date the call happened, so as to not duplicate efforts.

At the end of each customer call any changes to customer health should be reflected in the customer's Gainsight account. You have a few ways to update the CSM Sentiment and Product Sentiment for an account's health score, described in Determining CSM Sentiment and Product Risk, the easiest of which is updating it directly when logging the call.

Best Practices for Note-Taking

- Write down your agenda (including questions you want to ask) in advance. This way you can quickly add your notes for the specific context.
- If you're comfortable in writing in Markdown format, use it to quickly structure your notes in real time.
- Allow yourself time directly after the call to clean up your notes. Avoid scheduling back-to-back meetings.
- Practice slowing down call conversations. Stopping the dialog for a few seconds to say "let me write that down" tells the customer what they said is important to you.
- Ask your SAE/AE/SA to take notes with you. After the meeting combine and add detail.
- Use Chorus to record your calls so there's less pressure for you to take note of everything.
- Sometimes it makes sense for somebody on the account team to go back through the call in Chorus to transcribe it.
- Write notes in whatever is easiest and always copy them to the source of truth meeting notes doc. If you can write them in the source of truth in the first place, you'll be more efficient and consistent, and your account team will be able to follow along real-time.

Cadence Call Topics

The below non-exhaustive list is simply suggestions for cadence calls, and other topics may be more important, so use the suggestions at your discretion.

There are two sections, General Suggestions is for topics that are good at any time, and Ephemeral Suggestions is for topics that are ephemeral, such as release-specific topics or requests from Product Managers.

General Suggestions

These are suggestions that can be used at any time on customer calls.

- Follow up on previously discussed items
- Questions about their strategic and business outcomes and review of progress
- Periodically (a couple times per year) ask about new goals or objectives they have coming up
- Review upcoming features and releases
- Questions relating to Stage Adoption
- Discovery questions about their usage, best practices, typical workflows, etc.
- Learn about the customer's preferred product areas by asking what they are mainly using in terms of tools, integrations, IDEs, languages, etc., in order to know what to highlight from new releases
- Discuss if there are any areas for user enablement or training
- Mention upcoming GitLab workshops/events in their region (or even ones in other regions)
- Questions about how they are leveraging other tools or integrations
- Updates on customer requested features
- Discuss if their users have any feedback, pain points, or blockers
- Ask if there is anything the CSM can assist on towards resolution (feature requests, support tickets, etc.)
- Ask about any gaps in or outdated information in Gainsight (watch an 8 minute video for recommendations!)
- If self-managed, review their current version, planned upgrades, and if they need Upgrade Assistance
- If self-managed, review if there are any planned, upcoming, or ongoing deployment changes (e.g. Geo, HA, etc.) and ensure they are familiar with support
- If self-managed, discuss their backup/recovery plans and if they have recently tested restoring from a backup
- If self-managed, discuss if they have signups enabled
- If self-managed, raise the importance of GitLab Security patches and use it as an additional argument to enable usage/service ping reports of GitLab
- If self-managed, emphasize the importance of opting-in to security alerts
- If using a collaboration project, the CSM can configure a scheduled job to create agenda issues on a monthly frequency. Instructions for that are in each collaboration project's instructions file.

Ephemeral Suggestions

For more timely discussion topics, please refer to the CSM Hot Sheet (GitLab internal link).

SECTION: customer-success/csm/csm-development.md

As a Customer Success Manager at GitLab, you should feel empowered to take the time to invest in yourself and your career, leaning into the 70-20-10 rule for development.

To be intentional about our commitment to continuous improvement, the first Friday afternoon of every calendar month is strongly encouraged to be protected and used for personal and professional development, either individually or in collaboration with other GitLab team members.

To this end, it is essential to understand what resources are available for your personal and professional development, and the remainder of this page strives to be a place for leadership and CSMs to contribute to the resources available for the progression and development of the CSM team.

Key handbook sections, roadmaps and L&D platforms for enablement

1. CSM Planned Enablement Roadmap for FY24

1. CSM Enablement Corner (updated Quarterly with Key Dates and CSM required actions)

<iframe src="https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/e/2PACX-1vTB9tOQWZ771-M2nrIQkqlpx3XF7f9q1xXbBRkW5D-UAYksak626FVn0Ovrj0j7rHDurML4N8f83IY/embed?start=false&loop=false&delayms=3000&slide=id.g23e5b58af0829" frameborder="0" width="960" height="569" allowfullscreen="true" mozallowfullscreen="true" webkitallowfullscreen="true"></iframe>

Customer Success Management - Learning and Development Resources

The content is divided into three key categories of competencies. LevelUp is GitLab's Learning Experience Platform for certifications, learning paths and more! If you have ideas about a course you'd like to develop, consider checking out the Learning Evangelist Training.

· Customer Success Management · Soft Skills · Technology and Domain Knowledge

· Customer Success Management

CSM Best Practises and Examples at GitLab

- Chorus Playlist gives you access to the recordings of the best CSM calls. The recordings are continuously updated, so keep this playlist bookmarked for best practices.

CSM Internship

- CSM Internship for learning

Customer Success Management

- Customer Success Management Fundamentals (LinkedIn Learning)

- Business Fundamentals for Customer Success Managers (LinkedIn Learning)
- Avoiding Common Pitfalls in Customer Success Management (LinkedIn Learning)
- Onboarding and Adoption Best Practices for Customer Success Management (LinkedIn Learning)
- Engagement Evaluation Best Practices for Customer Success Management (LinkedIn Learning)
- Value Realization Best Practices for Customer Success Management (LinkedIn Learning)
- Building Rapport with Customers (LinkedIn Learning)
- Customer Experience: Journey Mapping (LinkedIn Learning)
- Advanced Business Development Communication & Negotiation (LinkedIn Learning)
- Sales: Customer Success (LinkedIn Learning)
- Customer Success by Nick Mehta, Dan Steinman, Lincoln Murphy, Maria Martinez (O'Reilly Books)
- The Customer Success Professional's Handbook (O'Reilly Books)
- Sales & Customer Success Learning Path in SQS: Parallel to the scheduled training sessions in the Sales Quick Start (SQS), with Role-based content (Instructor-Led Sessions)

Leadership

- CSM Aspiring Leaders Program

Executive Communication

As CSMs have positioned themselves to be more strategic and reach Director, VP, and CISO personas, we have to adjust our communication styles and consider how to cater them for executives. These resources will aid CSMs with executive presence and communication.

- We have two team members in L&D who are certified in Crucial Conversations. We have 1-2 sessions per quarter.
- Connecting with Executives
- Issue: Executive Communication Best Practices
- Google Doc (Actively being updated) - Lee Faus, Brian Wald, and Francis Ofungwu share themes (four pillars) they are hearing from executives around GitLab's platform
- Sandler Articles
 - How to Use DISC Assessments to Appropriately Customize Workplace Communication (Article)
 - Up Front Contracts (Article)
- Pyramid Principle for Slide Presentation (Article)
- Tim Ferris - how I prepare for keynotes (Article)

Public Speaking and Enablement

- Top Facilitation Techniques and Tactics For Great Remote Workshops - 16 minutes, timestamped per question (YouTube Video)
- How to Create and Run a Brilliant Remote Workshop - 48 minutes, listen to Part 2 but know that GitLab will advise on tools to use for your workshops. (LinkedIn Learning)
- GitLab Speaker Training - 35 minutes, requirement for external speakers about GitLab
- Tips & Tricks for an Engaging Remote Workshop (Article)
- How to Run an Engaging Remote Workshop: Tips for Stress-Free Collaboration (Article)
- 10 tips on how to deliver an engaging remote workshop (Article)
- Communicating with Confidence (LinkedIn Learning)
- Dynamic Public Speaking by University of Washington (Coursera)
- Storytelling and influencing: Communicate with impact (Coursera)

- Soft Skills

- Professional Soft Skills Learning Pathway (LinkedIn Learning)
- Kind Engineering: How to Engineer Kindness (YouTube)
- Secrets to Optimal Client Service (YouTube)
- Selling Solutions vs Solving Problems (YouTube)
- Psychological Safety: Clear Blocks to Innovation, Collaboration, and Risk-Taking (LinkedIn Learning)
- Improving Your Listening Skills (LinkedIn Learning)
- The Six Morning Habits of High Performers (LinkedIn Learning)
- Unconscious Bias (LinkedIn Learning)
- How to Make Strategic Thinking a Habit (LinkedIn Learning)
- Leading with Emotional Intelligence (LinkedIn Learning)

- Technology and Domain Knowledge

GitLab for CSMs

- Customer Success Education & Enablement (All-CS)
- Self Certifications are available on LevelUp. Each exam has a corresponding free, self-paced course that covers the needed knowledge and skills:
 - GitLab Certified Git Associate
 - GitLab Certified Project Management Associate
 - GitLab Certified CI/CD Associate
 - GitLab Certified Security Specialist
- Learning GitLab (LinkedIn Learning)
- Continuous Delivery with GitLab (LinkedIn Learning)
- Introduction to GitLab CI & DevOps with AWS (YouTube)
 - Introduction to GitLab CI & DevOps with AWS - Course Notes (Git Repo)
- GitLab CI CD Tutorial for Beginners (YouTube)

DevOps

- DevOps Foundations (LinkedIn Learning)

Software Development

- Software Development Life Cycle (SDLC) (LinkedIn Learning)

DevSecOps

- Get started with GitLab application security
- Application Security in DevSecOps (LinkedIn Learning)

Git

- Git Basics Episode 1 - What is Version Control? (External Video)
- Git Basics Episode 2 - What is Git? (External Video)
- Git Basics Episode 3 - Get Going with Git (External Video)
- Git Basics Episode 4 - Quick Wins with Git (External Video)

Markdown

- Handbook Markdown Guide
- GitLab Flavored Markdown (GLFM)
- Handbook Style Guide
- Markdown Tutorial

Docker

- Docker Crash Course for Absolute Beginners (YouTube)
- Docker Desktop on your Mac

Kubernetes

- What is Kubernetes - Kubernetes explained in 15 mins (YouTube)
- Kubernetes Crash Course for Absolute Beginners (YouTube)

How PS Technical Instructors Teach Technical Concepts

These are videos of actual 8-hour courses given live to customers by GitLab's Education Services department. These are good examples of how to present technical concepts in a structured format.

> The Education Services team is working on shorter, edited versions of these class videos. They'll replace these links with the edited versions when they're available. For now just fast-forward through labs and breaks in these unedited class recordings.

Access codes and recording links can be found in this internal doc.

Career development

Within the CSM job family

- The CSM Job Family page is kept updated with the roles and responsibilities of each level within the CSM job family
- The CSM Skills Matrix enables a CSM to determine areas of opportunity in working towards their next level of seniority

Within the CS org

- The SA Job Family page is kept update with the roles, responsibilities and technical expectations of an SA. For CSMs interested in moving into SA roles, they can work with their managers on learning paths to develop the technical and sales skills where needed.

Within GitLab, outside of CS

- While there is no 'formula' for moving into roles in other teams, we welcome CSM growth and desire to explore alternative areas with GitLab. For CSMs looking to move into different groups outside of CS, the first step is to review the job family requirements and connect with their manager on determining a path. It is encouraged for managers to connect with the group's team leaders in question to build out a development plan that will have the best chances of success.

SECTION: customer-success/csm/csm-internship.md

This page describes best practices for an internship for learning with the CSM team.

Internships are a great way for a GitLab team member to learn about being a Customer Success Manager at GitLab. Use this guide for planning and executing an internship under an IC CSM who acts as the 'Intern Mentor'.

How to find a mentor in the CSM team

The first step you will need to take in order to start an internship in Customer Success is to find a mentor from the CSM team. Feel free to reach out to any CSMs, particularly ones who are in a similar timezone to you to discuss an internship, or to reach out to a CSM Manager for guidance.

If you're not sure who to reach out to, you can also post in the customer-success Slack channel and express your interest in an internship and that you are looking for a mentor.

Internship expectations

An internship with the CSM team typically lasts 3 months and is intended for the intern to get hands-on experience of being a CSM, so that they can make a decision if being a CSM is aligned with their career goals and if so will be ready to apply for a position when one opens. Completing the internship is not a guarantee of moving into a CSM role.

Interns and mentors should agree to a regular cadence of meeting. The recommendation is a weekly 30-minute call, perhaps extending to 1-hour depending on the agenda. The intern should be ready and able to commit at least 8 hours per week to the internship (20% time).

Pre-internship tasks

1. The intern must get approval from their manager to participate in the internship
1. The intern must get agreement from a CSM to be their mentor
1. The mentor must get approval from their manager to participate in the internship
1. All parties (intern, mentor, and the two managers) must agree on a start date and weekly time commitment
1. The intern can optionally open an issue in the People Ops Training project using the Internship for learning template
1. The intern is responsible for scheduling a weekly recurring 1:1 with their mentor to foster regular communication regarding intern role and responsibilities, which will include creating and maintaining a notes doc to document the internship plan, progress, and take notes during

weekly 1:1s

1. The mentor will add the intern to the timtams Slack channel, Global CSM biweekly team call, and the mentor's team call
1. The intern is expected to provide feedback on their experiences and receive feedback and guidance throughout the internship

Timeline and Framework

Interns and mentors can follow the below guidelines to guide the internship and ensure the intern has a full range of exposure to being a CSM.

Week 1

Kick-off call

1. The intern and mentor will have their first call, in which they will get to know each other, agree on what they intend to get out of the internship, and align on the plan.
1. The mentor will invite the intern to their upcoming customer calls (the mentor may choose to invite the intern directly, or simply create a separate invite just for them with the Zoom link).

Async Material Review

In order to make the most of the internship, it's expected for the intern to do async handbook review in order to have a baseline knowledge of the GitLab product and how the CSM team works.

1. Read pages in the handbook
 1. CSM handbook, especially CSM responsibilities
 1. Account teams
 1. Solutions Architect and CSM overlap
 1. Support team overview
 1. Professional Services offerings
 1. What is Version Control
 1. Git-ing started with Git
 1. Start using Git on the command line
 1. Learn Git Branching
 1. GitLab Flow (video and documentation/)

Week 2

1. Shadow your mentor on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls
 1. Discuss with your mentor what work is involved before and after the call itself, have them share their screen as they do "admin work", and have them cc you on any communications before or after
1. Review one category of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Create
 1. Read through the Product Categories
 1. Complete the GitLab Certified Git Associate Learning Path
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. How does this category provide value to a customer?
 1. Why would a customer choose GitLab over a competitive tool?

1. What features are most interesting to you and why?
1. How would you approach discussing adoption of this use case with a customer?

Week 3

1. Shadow your mentor on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls
1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Plan
 1. Read through the Product Categories
 1. Complete the GitLab Certified Project Management Associate Learning Path
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. How does this category provide value to a customer?
 1. Why would a customer choose GitLab over a competitive tool?
 1. What features are most interesting to you and why?
 1. How would you approach discussing adoption of this use case with a customer?

Week 4

1. Shadow your mentor on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls
1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Verify
 1. 1. Read through the Product Categories
 1. Begin working on the GitLab CI Fundamentals Learning Path (modules 1-3)
 1. Based on what you read about the categories, be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. How does this category provide value to a customer?
 1. Why would a customer choose GitLab over a competitive tool?
 1. What features are most interesting to you and why?
 1. How would you approach discussing adoption of this use case with a customer?
1. Read the cadence calls handbook page
 1. Prepare a sample agenda for an upcoming cadence call based on one of the customer calls you've shadowed and present it to your mentor

Week 5

1. Shadow your mentor on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls
 1. Get recommendations from your mentor on other CSMs whose calls you can shadow in order to get perspective from other customers and CSMs
1. Working with your mentor, take ownership of customer questions and follow ups, for example:
 1. Get experience researching docs, asking questions in Slack, etc.
 1. Practice finding feature requests
 1. Practice making feature requests
 1. What is the product team looking for? What questions do you need to ask your customer?
 1. Escalate a support ticket - what does the process look like, how do CSMs interact with support?
 1. Draft a follow up email for the mentor to send to a customer
1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Verify & Package
 1. Read through the Package Product Categories
 1. Continue working on the GitLab CI Fundamentals Learning Path (modules 4-6)
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. Any modules/topics you struggled with understanding in the learning path
 1. Any questions you got wrong in the knowledge checks and what the correct answer is and why

- 1. Any roadblocks you ran into with the hands-on labs
- 1. How you would translate what you learned in the course to a customer conversation in order to increase CI adoption
- 1. Review the most recent release notes and give a short presentation/demo to your mentor on 1-2 new features

Week 6

- 1. Shadow other CSMs on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls, helping with follow ups and questions as needed
- 1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Verify & Release
 - 1. Read through the Release Product Categories
 - 1. Complete the GitLab Certified CI/CD Associate Exam
 - 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 - 1. Questions in the knowledge check that you got wrong, what the correct answer is, and why
 - 1. Prompts in the hands-on lab that you struggled to understand or complete, what the correct answer is, and why
 - 1. If available, review your score with your mentor to identify areas of improvement if you need to take the course again
- 1. Review account triage
 - 1. Ask your mentor to share their screen and walk through a customer's Gainsight 360, including scorecards, health updates in Timeline, and product usage data
 - 1. Review customer escalations and the process
 - 1. Schedule a coffee chat with a CSM currently managing or who recently closed an escalation in order to learn about their experience

Week 7

- 1. Shadow other CSMs on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls, helping with follow ups and questions as needed
- 1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Secure
 - 1. Read through the Product Categories
 - 1. Begin working on the GitLab Certified Security Specialist Learning Path (lessons 1-5 in GitLab Security Essentials)
 - 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 - 1. How does this category provide value to a customer?
 - 1. Why would a customer choose GitLab over a competitive tool?
 - 1. What features are most interesting to you and why?
 - 1. How would you approach discussing adoption of this use case with a customer?
- 1. Read through the account onboarding handbook page
 - 1. Choose an existing customer or create a fake one, and prepare for a kickoff call with them, including a deck using the template provided
 - 1. Present the deck to your mentor, with them acting as the customer
 - 1. After you finish roleplaying, self-reflect and get feedback from your mentor
 - 1. If available, shadow your mentor or another CSM as they prepare for and give a kick-off call, including follow ups
 - 1. Discuss with your mentor the additional work involved beyond the kick-off calls, such as creating a collaboration project, updating Gainsight fields and CTAs, and best practices for the transition process (both from pre-sales to CSM and CSM-to-CSM)

Week 8

1. Shadow other CSMs on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls, helping with follow ups and questions as needed
1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Secure & Software Supply Chain Security
 1. Read through the Software Supply Chain Security Product Categories
 1. Continue working on the GitLab Certified Security Specialist Learning Path (lessons 6-10 in GitLab Security Essentials)
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. Any modules/topics you struggled with understanding in the learning path
 1. Any questions you got wrong in the knowledge checks and what the correct answer is and why
 1. Any roadblocks you ran into with the hands-on labs
 1. How you would translate what you learned in the course to a customer conversation in order to increase CI adoption
 1. Read about success plans
 1. If you have access to Salesforce, choose a real customer and build a success plan for them using the template based on the command plan, product usage data, and any research you can do independently (without looking at the existing success plan if it exists!).
 1. If you do not have access to Salesforce, ask your mentor to choose a customer and share their command plan details and usage data with you.
 1. Present the success plan to your mentor and get feedback
 1. Ask your mentor to share a success plan of theirs, then review it and provide constructive feedback on it: what's done well, what could be improved in your opinion, and what questions would you ask the customer to fill in any gaps
 1. Discuss approaches CSMs can take to upgrade a customer to Ultimate

Week 9

1. Shadow other CSMs on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls, helping with follow ups and questions as needed
1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Secure
 1. Complete the GitLab Certified Security Specialist Exam
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. Questions in the knowledge check that you got wrong, what the correct answer is, and why
 1. Prompts in the hands-on lab that you struggled to understand or complete, what the correct answer is, and why
 1. If available, review your score with your mentor to identify areas of improvement if you need to take the course again
1. Review the most recent release notes and give a short presentation/demo to your mentor on 1-2 new features

Week 10

1. Shadow other CSMs on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls, helping with follow ups and questions as needed
1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Configure
 1. Read through the Product Categories

1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. How does this category provide value to a customer?
 1. Why would a customer choose GitLab over a competitive tool?
 1. What features are most interesting to you and why?
 1. How would you approach discussing adoption of this use case with a customer?
1. Learn about Architecture/HA and what's best for each customer
 1. Learn about HA and our reference architectures
 1. What is HA?
 1. Review architecture overview documentation
 1. Understand the differences between the different reference architectures
 1. Complete HA Certification course (pre-Gitaly) - note this course is no longer graded, but still helpful in learning about HA
 1. Review Gitaly documentation
 1. Understand our GitLab Dedicated offering
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. Ask them to share an architecture diagram from one of their customers
 1. Why a customer would choose SaaS vs self-managed vs Dedicated
 1. What you would tell a customer who has 500 users but wants to be HA
 1. Recommended upgrade paths and frequencies
1. Review Geo and discuss with your mentor the different use cases and why customers should use it and when
 1. Documentation
 1. Geo FAQ

Week 11

1. Shadow other CSMs on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls, helping with follow ups and questions as needed
1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: Monitor
 1. Read through the Product Categories
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. How does this category provide value to a customer?
 1. Why would a customer choose GitLab over a competitive tool?
 1. What features are most interesting to you and why?
 1. How would you approach discussing adoption of this use case with a customer?
1. Read about Executive Business Reviews (EBRs)
 1. Read about managing executive relationships
 1. Complete EBR micro-course
 1. Roleplay booking an EBR on a call with your mentor
 1. Look through Chorus if you have access or ask your mentor for recordings of successful EBRs
 1. Based on the success plan you created in week 8, build an EBR deck using the EBR template deck and present it to your mentor
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. What benefit do EBRs provide to us?
 1. What benefit do EBRs provide to the customer?
 1. What constitutes a successful vs a non-successful EBR?
 1. What was the hardest part about preparing an EBR?
 1. What would be your follow ups after an EBR?
1. Shadow another CSM and help them prepare for a real EBR if one is coming up

Week 12

1. Shadow other CSMs on customer calls, team calls, & account team calls, helping with follow ups and questions as needed
1. Review one stage of the DevSecOps lifecycle in depth every week: AI
 1. Read through GitLab Duo offering
 1. Be prepared to discuss with your mentor:
 1. How does AI provide value to a customer?
 1. Why would a customer choose GitLab over a competitive tool?
 1. What features are most interesting to you and why?
 1. How would you approach discussing adoption of AI with a customer?
1. Give a plan-to-monitor demo to your mentor, covering what you've learned at a high-level
 1. The demo should be focused on value of the entire DevSecOps lifecycle, but you should be prepared to go deeper into any areas or features, as your mentor will act as a customer and ask you probing questions
1. Celebrate! You've completed the CSM internship :tada:

SECTION: customer-success/csm/csm-okrs.md

For more information visit GitLabs Objective and Key Results (OKRs) page.

Purpose

This page provides an overview of CSM team issue tracking, OKRs, and the OKR process.

OKRs should provide continuous strategic alignment with the business. Our Big Rocks are our annual OKRs and our quarterly OKRs contribute to them.

GitLab.com (Epics/Issues) is THE best place to track the work we are doing! The goal is a streamlined way to submit ideas, have those prioritized and agreed and then coordinate the team to work on key focus areas to get the job done. We can't work on everything at once, so we aim to empower everyone to submit ideas and collaborate while keeping actual work focused on core priorities.

Additionally, this process should lead the way in leveraging GitLab features to demonstrate we can eat our own dog food and live a customer's life in our day-to-day duties. The team should have a single process to provide updates on progress and communicate the likelihood of achieving the outcomes below:

- Leadership able to easily track work across teams
- Team-level organization to see progress and where help is needed
- Managers support in 1:1s with an improved view of individual team member's internal work

As is the case with all our work, the development of the process to track our work within the

CS team is iterative and so it is recommended that you bookmark this page and check back frequently as this process is fine tuned.

Terminology

- Objective: The Mission
- Key Results: Measures of movement and behavior
- Initiatives: Activities that we theorise will move the key results in a direction that brings us closer to achieving the Objective.

Why is it Important We Do This Now?

- Improved visibility of team workload and priorities
- Streamlined idea submission and review process
- Enhanced ability to track progress and identify bottlenecks
- Better alignment of work with strategic priorities
- Increased transparency and collaboration within the team
- Data-driven decision-making through GitLab's reporting features

Principles

OKRs Should be Inclusive (Segments, regions etc) and lean in to heavily into our bias towards asynchronous contributions.

Objectives

- Outcome over output
- Inspirational and aspirational
- Avoid overlapping objectives
- Business aligned

Key Results

- Measurable
- Standard format: <Verb> <measure> from <x> to <y>
- Leading and lagging measures
- No more than 3 to 5 Key Results per OKR

What Impact will this have to GitLab and its Customers?

This will have significant impacts on both GitLab and its customers:

For GitLab

- Demonstrates the effectiveness of GitLab's own tools for project management
- Improves internal efficiency and productivity of the CS AMER team
- Enhances cross-functional collaboration and transparency
- Provides real-world use cases and feedback for product improvements
- Strengthens the company's "eat our own dog food" philosophy

For Customers

- Leads to more responsive and efficient customer support
- Provides a relatable example of GitLab usage for project management
- Potentially results in improved features based on internal feedback
- Demonstrates GitLab's commitment to using and improving its own products

Data Model

- Issues: Represents an Idea or Project to be undertaken. An Issue should represent no more than a quarter of duration of an activity. If it is more than a quarter, we should break it down into multiple issues.
- Labels: Will be used to track additional reporting attributes and manage workflow state
- Epic: Should indicate/tie an Issue back to a Strategic Objective / Pillar for CS
- Milestone: Should be the fiscal quarter we are planning to deliver & close the work. Milestones will be used to track both OKRs and non-OKR initiatives. OKRs should be defined in the OKR project within CSMERM and all non-OKR initiatives should be defined under the relevant team's subgroup.

Process

GLQL Tracking Table

Whereas previous iterations used issue boards for tracking work, the team is currently using a GLQL tracker within the CSMERM wiki.

Proposing OKRs

Idea Submission

- Team members choose the appropriate subgroup and project for their issue. These are organized by region and role, with one subgroup for cross collaboration between these. If you are unsure which project to open your issue in, default to your team's region and role (e.g. a CSM located in AMER would choose subgroup AMER CS and project CSM), or ask your manager for guidance.
- Team members create new issues with the CS-Status::Proposed scoped label.
- Use the issue template below for consistent information capture. The template should capture:
 - 30-sec elevator pitch
 - Why is it important we do this now? Is this due to an OKR?
 - What impact will this have to GitLab and its customers?
 - Team member and resource support to get it done?
 - Estimated Effort and ETA

Ownership and Resourcing

- Once prioritized, projects will be assigned a CS Manager as DRI
- Using a CS Manager as DRI ensures we have visibility across the CS leadership team and can fairly represent the workload in any further resourcing/prioritization discussions
- In addition to the CS Manager, at least one Senior/Staff CSx team member should be assigned to lead the discussion and at least one additional CSx team member to assist with the effort. If at least 2x team members can't be identified to drive the issue to closure, then please realign with the CS Manager to discuss whether this is a current priority or should wait for additional team member availability.

Review and Prioritization

- Regular management team meetings to review CS-Status::Proposed issues
- Categorize and prioritize issues using the labeling system (this should link to the labeling system section below)
- Include Mgr CS as DRI
- Identify 2x CSx, at least one Staff/Senior to manage the issue
- Remove the CS-Status::Proposed label after review

Workload Management

- Use CS-Priority::Top-5 label for immediate action items determined by Mgr CS (This would

include when tied back to a Big Rock or OKR)

- Assign CS-Priority::High issues to the current sprint/work cycle determined Mgr CS
- Utilize GitLab boards for workflow visualization
- Reference the GLQL tracker referenced above as a dashboard

Backlog Management

- Non-priority issues remain in the backlog
- Regular backlog review and reprioritization
- Use milestones for future sprint planning

Progress Tracking

- Implement time tracking on issues
- Use the CS-Status::Concern scoped label for issues facing obstacles and require leadership assistance
- Use the CS-Status::On Track scoped label for issues progressing as expected
- Use the CS-Status::On Hold scoped label for issues that are temporarily paused

Triage Bot Policies

Triage bot utilizes policies to determine what actions to perform on what items.

Each policy contains rules for the resource set. These rules are contained within an array that detail what to run on and what to actually do. Triage bot fields are:

Missing Field	Example
-----	----
GitLab Department	Customer Success
Issue Assignee	@csmname
CS-Priority Label	~"CS-Priority::Top-5"
CS-Team Label	~"CS-Team::CSM"
CS-Status Label	~"CS-Status::On Track"
CS-Region Label	~"CS-Region::AMER"
OKR/Initiative label	~"OKR"
LT Sponsorship label	~"CSLT::CS DIR NAME"
Milestone	~FYXXQX CS OKR
XLT DRI label	~"CSXLT::MGR CS NAME"

Completion and Review

When the work is complete, label the issue with CS-Status::Ready for Review to indicate that it

is done and needs final review by CS Managers and potentially external stakeholders.

- Prior to tagging CS-Status::Ready for Review, conduct retrospectives and provide summary lessons learned on the issue. Ensuring we have Lessons Learnt or Objectives Achieved allows us to share & celebrate the work done and completed.

- Post Review, if no other action is required, move completed issues to "Done" on the board.

Labeling System

Each issue should have labels and field values to satisfy the triage bot policies listed above. Below is a table of definitions for each label used in our tracking schema.

Category	Label	Definition
GitLab Department	Customer Success	Defines the relevant GitLab department as Customer Success for global OKR tracking
OKR/Initiative	OKR or Initiative	Required label for tracking OKRs and non-OKR initiatives respectively across GitLab
CS-Status	CS-Status::On Track	Issue is progressing as expected
CS-Status	CS-Status::Watchpoint	Issue is running behind and needs re-alignment on objective timeline between DRI team
CS-Status	CS-Status::Concern	Issue has significant obstacles that jeopardize completion by due date and require leadership assistance
CS-Status	CS-Status::Proposed	Issue has been proposed to CS leadership but not yet approved
CS-Status	CS-Status::Not Started	Issue has been identified but work has not yet begun
CS-Status	CS-Status::On Hold	Issue is temporarily paused
CS-Status	CS-Status::Closed Success	Issue has been successfully completed
CS-Status	CS-Status::Closed Not A Priority	Issue was determined to be not be a priority and closed
CS-Status	CS-Status::Ready for Review	Work on the issue is completed and is ready for signoff from leadership
CS-Priority	CS-Priority::Top-5	Top-5 OKR being tracked by CS leadership
CS-Priority	CS-Priority::High	OKR or initiative that significantly impact CS team objectives and metrics
CS-Priority	CS-Priority::Medium	OKR or initiative that moderately impact CS team objectives and metrics
CS-Priority	CS-Priority::Low	"Nice-to-have" OKR or initiative that would be beneficial but aren't critical
CS-Region	CS-Region::Global	Organization-wide objective
CS-Region	CS-Region::AMER	AMER specific objective
CS-Region	CS-Region::EMEA	EMEA specific objective
CS-Region	CS-Region::APAC	APAC specific objective
CS-Team	CS-Team::CSM	Customer Success Manager team
CS-Team	CS-Team::CSA	Customer Success Architect team
CS-Team	CS-Team::On Demand (CSE)	Customer Success Engineer team
CS-Team	CS-Team::RM	Renewal Manager team
CS-Team	CS-Team::Tech-Touch	Tech-Touch (Digital Experience) team
CS-Team	CS-Team:: Onboarding	Onboarding team

LT Sponsorship	CSLT::[Name]	CS Director+ who is sponsoring OKR or initiative
XLT DRI	CSXLT::[Name]	CS Manager who is DRI for OKR or initiative
XLT DRI	CSXLT::N/A	For use when a CS Director+ is the DRI rather than a CS Manager

OKR Schedule

The CSM OKR timeline is as follows:

Quarter Start	Task
4 weeks out	VP shares top goals with leadership team for feedback
4 weeks out	Leadership team collaboratively draft goals for next quarter and agree DRIs
4 weeks out	Leadership team review current OKR status
2 weeks out	Leadership team 50 minute draft review meeting. After, OKRs are put into GitLab and links are shared in csm-updates Slack channel
2 weeks out	Leadership team discusses with their respective teams and polishes OKRs
1 week out	Closing ceremony and playback of previous OKRs
0	Update OKRs to be active

Additional Resources

Short tutorial of process

SECTION: customer-success/csm/customer-collaboration-project.md

View the CSM Handbook homepage for additional CSM-related handbook pages.

The Customer Collaboration Project

A customer collaboration project facilitates the collaboration and partnership of the customer and GitLab with dogfooding means. It provides transparency and accountability to all involved parties. Additionally, it enables the teams to continuously exchange documentation and track changes within the teams. The Customer Collaboration Project is typically used when a prospective customer is approaching the stage where a Proof of Value is needed.

Where to find the Customer Collaboration Projects

The Customer Collaboration Projects are located in a Sub-Group, called gitlab-com/account-management/, of GitLab-com so members of the Sales and Customer Success team can create Projects to collaborate with their customers and prospective customers.

Access is granted to members of the timtams Group (ID: 3174702) on gitlab.com.

The projects are further ordered into Sub-Groups by region:

- Western North America

- Eastern North America
- EMEA - Europe, the Middle East and Africa
- APAC - Asia & Pacific Accounts
- Commercial - Commercial Account Management
- Public-Sector

Use cases for the Customer Collaboration Projects

- The encompassing group for the customer collaboration project has space for other special projects (Proof of Value, Value stream assessment, different Subscription at the customer) or an Group access token - API key for automations.
- Agenda Issue for cadence or other meetings with the customer, via agenda issue template or on group Level.
- Conversations about Initiatives with the Customer, including collaborating with other GitLab members by @ mentioning into this issue.
- Async Planning of Enablement Sessions @ mentioning GitLab contributors in the issue.
- Async retrospectives, with retrospective issue creation.
- SA (Solution Architect) activities tracked for example demos or POVs.
- Architecture diagram with history (git history).
- List of Members in the Zendesk Support Shared Organization maintained by the customer with full history for governance (git history).
- TAM Issue tracker Tracking of product feature requests.
- Interacting with the Product Team and Prioritizing Customer issues.
- Public Pages for Issue creation.
- ServiceDesk Function, to enable other users of the customer without a role in the Customer Collaboration Project to create issues. The CSM should notify the customer that the Collaboration Project is not meant for product support and troubleshooting inquiries.
- Sharing service ping metrics, graphics, and Usage metrics guides via PDF, CSV with GitLab from the Customer (configure Collab project for LFS).
- Storing EBR and other meeting recordings (configure Collab project for LFS).
- Store Meeting Minutes.
- Providing the GitLab Support Team and their Architecture Diagrams app access to the Infrastructure Diagram
- GitLab exploration. Allowing the customer access to an Ultimate tier namespace can come in handy for exploration of uses they may not have access to in their own instance. Also, it exposes them to our use of issues/epics/boards and may drive some interest in expanding their own use of these features.
- Issue Boards with scoped labels as workflow states.
- Provide:
 - Training recommendations.
 - Important links & resources.
- The use cases of Pre-Sales assets are described in this Handbook Page: Solutions Architecture Collaboration Project

Setup a Customer Collaboration Project for Customer Success Managers

Projects should be created with a Visibility Level of Private.

Please follow these instructions when you receive a customer from pre-sales

1. Check with the SA or SAE if a collaboration project was used in pre-sales, it should be located in account-management/pre-sales.
2. Check in with the SAE and SA if they want to remove issues before the move.
3. If the project exists, create a subgroup in gitlab-com/account-management//[SEGMENT] named like the customer.
4. Navigate to the existing collaboration project.
5. Go to Settings > General > Expand Advanced Settings > Transfer Project - move the project to gitlab-com/account-management//[SEGMENT]/[CUSTOMER-GROUP].

Please follow these instructions when a Customer Collaboration Project does not exist

The Customer Collaboration Project template contains pre-populated issues, labels, milestones, documentation and information necessary to facilitate a collaboration project with a customer.

The customer's team should be included on the project and begin to work collaboratively together on the success and enablement of the customer and their relationship with GitLab.

1. Create a subgroup in the appropriate subgroup gitlab-com/account-management//[SEGMENT] named like the customer (Visibility Level should be Private).
2. Go to this subgroup gitlab-com/account-management//[SEGMENT]/[CUSTOMER-GROUP].
3. Click 'Create New Project'
4. Click 'Create from template'
5. In the top filter (e.g. Built-in, Instance, Group), Select 'Group'
6. Click 'Use template' next to the Customer Collaboration Project Template
7. Prefix the name of the new project with Customer Name
8. Go to the settings of the new project and change the project avatar to the customer's logo
9. Complete the README file - make sure you replace all areas where there are [SQUARE BRACKETS] around text with the appropriate customer information
 1. IMPORTANT: This README is customer facing. Please be thorough when filling out sections and use customer presentable language that demonstrates a strong understanding of their needs and requirements.
10. Invite the customer's team as direct members to the Customer Collaboration Project with 'Developer' role
11. Discuss with the customer if some of their team members should have the 'Maintainer' role, so that they can manage the users themselves.
12. Subscribe to new issues in the Project and all applicable labels.
13. Adjust the Feature Request and Agenda issue Templates in your collaboration project. The other issue templates are on Group Level.
14. Introduce the customer to the collaboration project.

Please follow these instructions when you receive a customer from another CSM

1. Update the contents of README file.
2. Check the direct members and settings of the Projects.
3. Subscribe to new issues in the Project and all applicable labels.

General Actions on a Customer Collaboration Project

1. Set the notification level on the Customer Collaboration Project to either "Watching" or "Custom" to get notified, if the customer opens an issue for example.

SECTION: customer-success/csm/devsecops-adoption-tracking.md

On This Page

Gainsight Process for Tracking DevSecOps Adoption

YouTube Video (private - GitLab internal only) guiding CSMs on the Gainsight process: How to create & correctly populate a DevSecOps objective & playbook

1. Immediately upon a net-new customer purchasing Ultimate or an existing Premium customer upgrading, open an Objective and apply the DevSecOps Enablement Playbook in the customer's ROI success plan.

1. Document when the customer intends to start implementing the security and compliance features (Rough date is fine) in the field created (bottom of CTA) once the CTA is opened (see video).

1. Document the customer's intended use cases and desired business outcomes and align on an adoption roadmap within the success plan (per the playbook). This roadmap needs to include:

- Why they bought ultimate (in the strategy section)
- Objectives focused on implementation, with tasks that have timelines
- Customer DRI listed in task

1. Begin taking the customer through the steps within the DevSecOps playbook, offering both an enablement session on the Get Started Guide and on our DevSecOps & Compliance Features and Best Practices.

1. If a customer is not able to move forward with the implementation

- Change the status of the enablement CTA to 'blocked'
- Record the date and reason for being blocked in the comments section
- Continue to update the comments section as new information pertaining to the blocked state is learned

SECTION: customer-success/csm/ebr.md

View the CSM Handbook homepage for additional CSM-related handbook pages.

For further details, visit: [GitLab Success Plans Documentation](#)

SECTION: customer-success/csm/engagement-survey.md

Overview

GitLab conducts an annual team member engagement survey to understand what team members feel we are doing well and what things we can improve. The Customer Success Management team gathers the survey results from our team members, and identifies action items to work on over the coming year.

This page is where we provide details on those action items, and ongoing updates on our progress.

FY22 Pulse Engagement Survey

The FY22 Pulse Engagement Survey was sent out in Q4 of FY22. From the results of that survey, the primary opportunity was around action being taken as a result of the survey. The CSM team was asked via a simple google survey the following questions:

1. With our focus on the CSM segmentations rolling out, and our Big Rock initiatives - is acting upon these initiatives and keeping the team updated what we want to see in regards to action being taken this year?

1. If no, what action would you like to see us take this year as a CSM team, as CSM and CS leadership?

Of the 11 responses received (25% response rate) all 11 said that the above focus is the right one to report action on this year.

How We Will Take Action & Report Results

1. This Epic board shows the relevant epics for the following points

1. Each Big Rock initiative is housed in an epic, with a CSM Manager DRI. CSMs are encouraged to contribute, and progress made is reported back to the team in the bi-weekly team meeting

1. The CSM segmentation is also housed in an epic, and roll-out is reported upon in the team meeting also.

SECTION: customer-success/csm/engaging-with-partners.md

Process for Engaging with Partners in CSM-Assigned Customer Accounts

CSM-Assigned Customer Accounts

Pre-Customer Kick-Off or 1st Engagement

1. GitLab Partner team introduces CSM & SAE/AE to Partner - ideally before sale closes to not slow down post-sales implementation

1. CSM and SAE/AE connects with Partner to align on the role the Partner will play post-sale.

- If the Partner has an ongoing engagement with the customer, CSM & Partner to align on post-sale Kick-Off call, collaborating on the Kick-Off deck content and ownership/roles for the call

- Determine if the Partner has planned ongoing cadence calls with the customers and how the CSM can best be included without creating duplication

- Determine who will invite the customer to the Kick-Off Call

- Determine agreed next steps from the Kick-Off call including agreement with customer of ongoing cadence of engagement

Customer Onboarding

1. GitLab's process and metrics for successful onboarding can be found here.

1. CSM and Partner are to work together to ensure the best possible experience for the customer, while not impacting key metrics such as Time to Engage and Time to 1st Value wherever possible.

Ongoing Cadence Calls

1. The CSM team follows these guidelines in holding cadence calls with customers. The CSM is to work with the Partner to align on how they can collaborate in regard to touchpoints with the customer, creating a seamless customer experience

Executive Business Reviews (EBR)

1. The CSM holds an EBR with their customer around month 6 of each contract year, the process for the EBR can be found here

1. Prior to setting up any EBR, the CSM is to sync with the partners to determine who will invite the customer, and collaborate on the content taking into account the GitLab template and the strategic initiatives of the partner.

Measuring Customer Health

1. The CSM has a series of health scorecards by which a CSM can manage of the key indicators of risk within a customer account.

1. The CSM and Partner are recommended to review the health of the account on an agreed cadence, with the least being quarterly and the most being monthly.

SECTION: customer-success/csm/engaging-with-ps.md

CSM Guidelines - Engaging with PS on a customer project

The following outlines the steps/means for a CSM to engage with Professional Services throughout a PS engagement with an existing customer. Once a project is closed-won in Salesforce, PS Ops engages with the customer to establish the key project criteria. Once this criteria is received, the project manager is assigned. The following steps are completed by the project manager:

1. Invites CSM to internal PS kick-off meeting (PSE, PM, CSM)
1. Invites CSM to Account Team (Sales) to PS transition meeting
1. Invites CSM to customer kick-off meeting
1. Invites CSM to join standups (weekly, daily, etc)

1. Invites CSM to PS slack channel
1. Invites CSM (as optional) to weekly status meeting with the customer and the entire project team.
1. Keeps CSM in the loop (and visa versa) regarding potential deal growth in either the licensing or services categories
1. Invites CSM to project closure meeting

CSM Responsibility

1. CSM feeds key information back to the project team such as future licensing deals, upgrades, etc.
1. CSM keeps up to date with progress via (slack channel, daily standups, weekly status meetings, status reports sent via email, etc.)

SECTION: customer-success/csm/executive-relationships.md

View the CSM Handbook homepage for additional CSM-related handbook pages.

At GitLab, successful partnerships between our Customer Success Managers and their customer executives are crucial to the success of our customers and our business. As CSMs position themselves to be more strategic and reach Director, VP, and CISO personas, we have to adjust our communication styles and consider how to cater them to executives. This page provides guidance on how CSMs can effectively partner with executives to drive value for our customers.

Persona Engagement Flow

Often, CSMs are first introduced to GitLab Admins and champions who work directly with GitLab in their day-to-day, or their direct team does. While this is incredibly useful, and we should be cultivating these relationships, we also want to have executive-level relationships. Typically the flow for a CSM is to start by building strong relationships with admins and champions, then have them introduce the CSM to their leadership, and repeat the cycle until we get in the room with a decision-maker.

Sometimes, we can establish an executive contact and relationship early on, whether because they are involved in the pre-sales process and the AE has a close relationship, or because the admin/champion has a direct link to them and is able to get them involved.

Build Relationships with GitLab Admin & Champions

Strong first impressions are important in building a successful and collaborative relationship with your customer. When being introduced to a new account, it is critical that you and the account team position the Customer Success Manager role as more than "technical support" or "technical point of contact." This limits the scope of the CSM role and lowers the probability of gaining access to executives. By positioning the CSM as a consultant focused on their business success and enablement, it opens up conversations around high-level business outcomes.

From there, asking deeper questions during the intro call is a great way to uncover the outcomes that are the highest priority for the customer. This could happen right after the initial sale, when you inherit a customer from another CSM, or even after having the account for a while in order to ensure continued alignment. Asking discovery questions such as those listed below are key to uncovering the problems your account is experiencing, the business impact of those problems, and the benefit that fixing those problems will have on their business.

- Why did you buy GitLab?
- What problems do you hope to solve?
- What is the impact of those problems on your business?
- What will solving those problems do for your business?
- What kind of results will tell you that you made the right decision in buying GitLab?
- What are the goals of your company short-term (3-6 months) and long-term (1+ years)?

It is critical to identify the champions and key influencers within the organization and make an effort to engage with them regularly. Schedule regular check-ins and provide updates on customer health, success stories, and any opportunities for growth or improvement. Oftentimes, successful customer partnerships require cross-functional collaboration. Make sure you work with your champion to identify stakeholders from other teams or departments that need to be involved in supporting the customer's success and coordinate efforts between the teams to ensure everyone is aligned on goals and priorities.

Sometimes, the day-to-day team might not understand the value of executive partnership and therefore defaults to gatekeeping us from engaging with executive personas, as they see us as "just another vendor". To handle this objection, CSMs should equip the team with value-led messaging to pitch Executive Business Reviews internally by displaying EBRs as great opportuni